

Week 06

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Documentation

Data Exploration - Audit

What the data source is and where it comes from

My primary data source is personal phone usage data, likely collected from built-in screen time tracking tools (such as iOS Screen Time or Android Digital Wellbeing). If needed, I may also supplement this with manually logged emotional reflections during or after phone use (e.g., quick mood tags recorded throughout the day).

What the data contains and how it is structured The dataset includes timestamps of phone usage, duration of app usage, and frequency of phone pickups. Each entry can be structured with fields such as:

- Time and date of use
- App or activity used
- Duration of session
- Self-reported emotional state (e.g., tired, happy, stressed, bored)

This creates a time-based dataset that can be mapped into a visual timeline where emotion is encoded through colour.

Limitations, Biases or Gaps

A key limitation is that emotional data is subjective and may be inconsistent or forgotten if recorded manually. Screen time data also does not explain why the phone was used, only how it was used. There is also potential bias in self-reporting emotions, as they may be simplified or influenced by hindsight. These limitations mean the final visualisation will show patterns rather than exact truths, encouraging interpretation and reflection rather than precise measurement.

Apple Screen Time Visualisations

What draws me to it?

- The clean, minimal structure makes behavioural data easy to understand at a glance.

What I might carry forward:

- The simplicity of time-based breakdowns and clarity in hierarchy.

Does it change my direction?

- It reinforces my idea of using a timeline as the core structure.

Georgia Lupi - Dear Data Project

What draws me to it?

- The hand-drawn, personal nature makes data feel emotional rather than mechanical.

What I might carry forward:

- The idea of subjective, human-centred data collection.

Does it change my direction?

- It strengthens my intention to include emotional interpretation, not just raw analytics.

Nicholas Felton Annual Reports (Feltron)

What draws me to it?

- The layered density of personal life data over time.

What I might carry forward:

- Combining multiple data types into one structured visual system.

Does it change my direction?

- It encourages me to include multiple layers (emotion + usage patterns).

Digital Emotion Mapping Visualisations

What draws me to it?

- The use of colour as a direct emotional language.

What I might carry forward:

- Mapping emotion to colour gradients or categories.

Does it change my direction?

- It reinforces my idea of colour-coded emotional timelines.

“Quantified Self” Movement Visualisations

What draws me to it?

- The focus on self-awareness through continuous tracking.

What I might carry forward:

- The idea of long-term behavioural pattern discovery.

Does it change my direction?

- It supports my goal of helping users reflect on habits over time.

Project Planning and Skills Roadmap

My final artefact will be a digital interactive visualisation that displays phone usage patterns over time through an emotional timeline dashboard. The interface will present time segments (such as hourly blocks or app sessions) along a timeline that can be explored by the user. Each segment will be colour-coded according to emotional state (for example: blue = tired, yellow = happy, red = stressed) to reveal emotional relationships with phone use.

The visualisation may take the form of an interactive horizontal timeline or circular dashboard showing daily behavioural patterns. Users will be able to interact with the visualisation through clickable or hover-based elements that reveal additional information.

Features of the digital artefact may include:

- Visual indicators showing peaks in phone usage
- Emotional transitions across different times of day
- Highlighting repeated behavioural patterns such as late-night scrolling when tired

- Interactive filters allowing users to explore specific emotions, app categories, or time periods
- Dynamic layers that reveal additional information when selected

The overall goal is to create a digital experience that helps users recognise emotional patterns behind unconscious phone habits and encourage self-reflection

Independent Study

Consultation Reflection

The proposal consultation helped me think more clearly about what my project is actually trying to achieve. One of the most useful discussions was around whether my project was more about visualising phone usage data or visualising emotions connected to phone use. Through the discussion, I realised that the emotional aspect is what makes the project more meaningful and personal.

Another useful point raised was about complexity. I originally wanted to experiment with multiple emotional layers and more complex visual systems, but the conversation helped me realise that making the project too complicated could make it harder to understand. This shifted my focus toward keeping the visual system simpler and easier to read.

As a result of this discussion, I want to be more deliberate about simplifying my emotional categories and focusing on patterns rather than perfect accuracy. Moving forward, I plan to spend more time testing small prototypes with real data before making larger design decisions so I can better understand what actually works visually.

Technical Skill Building

To improve this skill, I experimented with creating a small dataset using phone usage information and emotional labels. I created simple categories such as tired, happy, stressed, neutral, and distracted, then organised these into a spreadsheet with timestamps and usage duration.

What I learned is that data structure is much more important than I expected. When information was inconsistent or too detailed, it became difficult to visualise clearly. Simplifying categories and creating consistent formatting immediately made the data easier to work with.

This process helped move my project forward because I now understand how raw information can be translated into a visual timeline. It also showed me that building a clear dataset first makes designing the visual outcome much easier later.

Sketch description:

- A horizontal timeline showing one day of phone usage
- Each phone session becomes a coloured block
- Colours represent emotions
- Blue = tired
- Yellow = happy
- Red = stressed
- Grey = neutral
- Bigger blocks represent longer periods of phone use
- Clicking or hovering on blocks shows more information
- Repeated colours help show patterns over time

This version is simpler than earlier ideas and focuses more on making emotional patterns easy to see and understand.